saw the BJP emerge as the single largest party, with 89 seats. It still needed the support of the Shinde Sena, which got 29 seats, to surpass the majority mark of 114. The Sena got its pound of flesh—installing Sanjay Ghadi as deputy mayor. However, it's clear that the pound is looking to get heavier, with Shinde's claim that his party will take the residual 1.25 years in the post.

Adding fuel to the fire, Sena leader and legislative council deputy chairperson Sachin Ahir is set to lead the party's charge in the election to the prestigious Mumbai District Central Cooperative Bank later this year. The bank, controlled by close Fadnavis aide and MLC Pravin Darekar, has a working capital of Rs 10,282 crore and disburses loans of around Rs 700 crore every year. It's the central financial agency of all affiliated housing cooperatives in Mumbai.

TAKING THE WHOLE BINARY

A senior Shinde Sena leader confirmed the party is planning to put up a panel of its own. "It's necessary for us to make our presence felt and avoid being swallowed up by the BJP. There's unrest in the ranks against the BJP," he adds. When asked, BJP spokesperson Navnath Ban fended off the idea of a contest, saying they would "fight the elections as the Mahayuti". A party senior, however, says the competition has value, since the BJP and the Sena are deftly carving out the Marathi and non-Marathi space between themselves, edging out the Opposition. "The Sena UBT and MNS are nowhere in the picture in the language debate. The Congress, too, failed to take up cudgels for north Indian taxi drivers though it has pockets of support in this cohort. The Mahayuti has captured space on both sides of the divide," he points out.

Political analyst Abhay Deshpande said Sarnaik's evangelical zeal was a public stance since the policy itself was doomed from the beginning. He ascribes it to Shinde's need to take positions that differ from that of his senior ally to show "his separate identity". ■

▶ KERALA

WHEN THE PURDAH FALLS IN BETWEEN

CM Satheesan, alliance partner IUML on opposite sides of a debate that puts a question of Sharia centrestage in Kerala

By **Jeemon Jacob**



IT WENT AROUND AS A HEARTWARMING REEL: the old idyll of Onam recast for our times. Throngs of youth, rapt in ecstatic dance, scarf-clad Muslim girls visibly in the mix, as *chenda* drums kept them moving as one. It was August 26, and flowers, feasts and festoons were all around—three occasions coincided on that date. It was Thiruvonam, the big festival day. Also, Eid ul-Milad. And V.D. Satheesan was completing 100 days as chief minister. It was as if the calendar had conspired to capture Kerala's social-political rainbow on one day.

Perhaps it was too idyllic. As if in revenge, a shadow soon came to be cast on the ruling United Democratic Front—or at least the political bond often seen as its basis. A hundred days ago, Satheesan was facing taunts for his proximity to the Indian Union Muslim League (IUML). That flowed from reliance: it was IUML backing that enabled him to pip AICC general secretary and Rahul Gandhi acolyte K.C. Venugopal to the CM's post. Now, the two friends find themselves on opposite sides

Takeaways

- **Grand mufti stirs row by saying women in public spaces "cause great ruin"**
- **CM calls it an outdated, "19th c" view not in sync with modernity or Islam**
- **Alliance partner IUML caught in a bind, forced into backing the clergy**